The Corridors of Hadrian

Eko Svenningsson

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Sneak preview: the Prologue and Chapter One of the v335 manuscript. The complete novel is available to agents and publishers on request.

"The cylinder seal does not preserve the clay; it marks the jurisdiction of the hand that closed it."
— Antonius de Soza, Field Notes on Administrative Provenance (1998, unpublished)

Preparers' Note

January 2027

This report is written in the third person by the two people it follows. We have written of ourselves as subjects are written in a file, by name in the account and by initials in the notes, because for most of these months that was the only way to keep the record honest. Where we did not see the same thing, both accounts are given.

N. Linder and O. Randolf

Prologue

Initial Contact Event

October 31, 2025

After closing, the Museum kept a second set of hours.

The doors closed to the public at six, and after that the building ran itself: security lights, climate control, relays clicking softly in the walls. Nina Linder knew these hours best because they asked the least of her, fewer voices and fewer faces and fewer reasons to explain herself. The cameras, badge readers and motion sensors kept watching. They recorded everything and stopped nothing.

Paper dust and dried methyl cellulose clung to her fingertips, a chalky residue the lab sink never quite removed. The conservation lab on the third floor of the west wing smelled of thymol and denatured alcohol, the sharp, patient smell of materials holding out against time. Under the raking lamp lay a clay tablet the size of her palm, supported by a ring of modern polyethylene foam. The tablet was the brown of dried river mud. Its face bore cuneiform, wedge-shaped writing pressed into the clay with a cut reed while it was still soft.[1] The ancient scribe might have needed only a few minutes, yet the writing had outlasted the city that needed it.

These pressed wedges were paperwork: inventory, payment, oath, letter. Someone had held this tablet and meant it to function.

The form beside it said VALDERRAMA ESTATE TRANSFER in crisp black type. Beneath it, in Nina's own hand: *incomplete provenance, donor pressure, accelerated display schedule.*

The Museum loved new gifts the way it loved openings, in a hurry to put an object on display before anyone understood it, before it could be contested, before facts could complicate the story.

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1. Cuneiform is a script rather than a language; the same writing system could record several languages. See Ira Spar, "The Origins of Writing," *Heilbrunn Timeline of Art History* (Metropolitan Museum of Art, 2004).

Earlier in the week she had worked through the estate's most valuable pieces: nine cylinder seals, thumb-sized stone rollers carved with lions and kings and stylized trees. Rolled across soft clay, each left a continuous band of its design, separate from any writing a scribe pressed into the surface. She had photographed each one in raking light, in macro and in profile, and logged them under temporary numbers, VAL-17-1 through VAL-17-9, with the weight in ounces, the diameter in inches and the surface wear mapped like a coastline.[2]

Her phone lay face down beside the lamp. For two hours she had been trying not to look at it. For almost four months she had been avoiding Owen Randolf, since the memorial for Antonius de Soza, known to them as Anton, where the two of them had talked for ninety seconds outside the reception-room doors.

The seals were no longer in the lab. Tomorrow there would be a donor reception, wine and velvet voices and trustees pretending they could hear history, and the seals were already waiting for it in a "New Acquisitions" vitrine in the Ancient Near East wing, under a temporary label that read like a promise:

THE VALDERRAMA BEQUEST.

Nina had argued against it. She had documented the gaps and asked for a longer review, time to do what her job actually was, and she had lost anyway, the decision made upstairs, where urgency was always called stewardship. Faith belonged to donors. Her work began with evidence. She stayed late all the same and cataloged the quieter pieces, the ones no one would put on a poster: the tablet, a fragmentary bronze weight, a broken amulet.

She checked the phone anyway, as she checked a hygrometer, for the reading and not for comfort: twenty minutes since the last look, forty before that. It was Friday, October 31, 2025. Alone under the low hum of the lab ventilation, among objects that had waited thousands of years to be read, she examined her hesitation as she would a repair joint beginning to separate under magnification, looking for the first place it had ceased to

2. N. Linder, Valderrama intake sheet, working copy. VAL-17 is the provisional series; the final element identifies an individual object. The tablet, bronze weight and amulet continue as VAL-17-10 through VAL-17-12. These numbers record temporary custody. The ownership chain and formal accession remain open on her copy.

hold.[3] Every reason she found led back to the same fear: he might answer, and she would have to say more.

One draft sat unsent in Messages, all restraint: *Are you safe?* The other was not a text at all. It lived in Notes, a paragraph she kept revising and had never sent. She kept the two like exhibits, one labeled and one in quarantine.

It doesn't matter, he won't answer anyway, she thought, for the tenth time that night.

It was twenty to nine. The Museum had gone over to its night settings, half the lights and none of the footsteps, nothing awake but the air handlers and the objects. She should leave, go home to Astoria, feed the cat, stand in her kitchen and pretend the silence was a choice.

She settled the tablet into its storage box and closed the lid, keeping the foam support in place. Coat on, bag on her shoulder, she reached for the lamp switch—

—and heard voices.

Charles was the guard on duty that evening, and he made his rounds alone. He had been on the night staff longer than almost anyone, and he always called the lab before locking the staff run, giving her another minute without asking why she needed it. He observed the rules without pretending they made him important; Nina had come to trust that about him, and to feel, without ever saying so, that the building was safer with him in it. What she knew for certain now was that the sound beyond the lab was not his voice. Several people were speaking low and rhythmically down the service passage toward the antiquities wings, thin at first, then swelling, stronger and more closely in unison.

Trespassers, perhaps. A late tour. Teenagers playing brave. The options ran through her head while the voices came again. She had heard curators pronounce dead languages with living authority, stopping to correct one another. This sounded different: syllables she did not recognize, every voice entering on the same beat.

She took out her phone and brought up Charles's number, meaning to let the building do what it had been designed to do: radios, lockdown, procedure. Then she did not call. If it was a curator rehearsing for tomor-

3. A stereo microscope lets a conservator inspect how a repair joins damaged fibers and where an adhesive bond has begun to separate. See Hannah Flock, Petra Demuth, Stefan Diebels and Elisabeth Jägers, "The Thread-by-Thread Tear-Mending Method," in *Conserving Canvas* (Getty Conservation Institute, 2023). Nina is looking for the first sign of parting, not testing a bond's strength.

row's reception, a call to security would turn it into an incident with her name on it. She wanted to see first.

"Just checking a sound," she said aloud, and shivered when the empty wing gave her voice back sounding like someone else's.

Kids would have broken up laughing by now. These voices stayed together, steady as one body.

She let the screen go dark in her palm and followed the sound. The lab opened onto a service passage, poorly lit, lined with storage rooms and mechanical access, and she walked it by habit; five years of carrying fragile things through spaces the public never saw had made this the part of the building where she felt most competent. It smelled of plaster and dry air.

Halfway down, a relay clicked behind the lights. Nina stopped. When nothing followed, she went on, keeping the dark screen against her palm so as not to announce herself.

The chanting grew clearer as she approached. At the end of the passage she lifted the badge clipped at her hip to the reader on the staff-only door and waited for the lock to release. Her pulse quickened. Whoever was ahead of her had already passed through a door that should have kept them out.

She pushed through into the galleries.

After hours the galleries felt unstaffed rather than empty.

She avoided the rotunda, with its sightlines and its cameras aimed at open floor, and took a narrower access hall toward the Ancient Near East wing, where the lamps were dimmed and the long cases laid their shadows across the floor in slanted bars.

Ahead, a warm light wavered across the ceiling, too amber for the security fixtures and too soft for a flashlight.

Nina slowed and woke the phone screen in her right hand. Charles's number was still there beneath her thumb.

At the gallery doorway she stopped, keeping the wall beside her shoulder.

Six people stood in a circle around the Valderrama display. The freestanding vitrine—a waist-high stone plinth designed to hold a heavy five-sided glass bonnet—had been opened with practiced care: the glass cover had been lifted off and set aside on the floor, two pairs of white cotton handling gloves laid neatly beside it, leaving the bare stone pedestal exposed. Whatever this was, it was no smash-and-grab.

The nearest of them was a woman in a gray cardigan, eyes closed, a staff lanyard still looped around her neck. Under the chant, a voice rose

above the others, then fell back into time with them. Someone said, "—not yet—", and the woman in the cardigan hushed the speaker sharply, as if he had disturbed her concentration, without opening her eyes. The lanyard carried the Museum's own logo; Nina had never seen the woman before.

On the pedestal at the center sat a cylinder seal Nina knew at once: VAL-17-3.

Rolled over a clay closure, the seal's design could show whose authority had closed a jar or secured a door. It belonged to someone's ordinary acts of possession and trust. She had weighed this one and photographed it and noted the hairline chip along its edge and the pale vein through the darker stone. To see it here, in a public gallery after hours and in an open case, was like seeing a notary's stamp laid on an altar.

Each figure held a lit candle. Nina could not help checking the pedestal for wax, where a spill could lodge against the seal, then the floor beneath their hands. She saw no drips. The smoke detector stayed silent.

Above the seal, perhaps an inch off the stone, hung a sphere of golden light that pulsed at the pace of their voices. As it expanded, marks cut into the hematite cylinder seemed to project upward into the glow, casting lines across its surface that appeared and dissolved in successive rotations.[4] Nina shifted her weight in the doorway; the light dimmed once and steadied, so quickly she could not tell whether anyone inside had noticed her. Anyone, or anything: the sphere itself seemed to have registered her while the group went on chanting.

Nina's training turned the scene into a list of violations: open flame, case breached, an unauthorized ceremony in a public hall, and beneath them a transgression much worse than any of these. Her eye returned to the opened case. Whoever had arranged this knew the seal, yet treated it as a tool they had a right to use.

They weren't stealing the seal.

They were using it.

The projected marks shifted across the glow. Nina tried to hold one in sight through a rotation; it dissolved before she could fix its position. Beneath it, a film of moisture gathered on the seal and vanished, over and

4. Hematite is a dark, hard iron-oxide stone used for cylinder seals. For an ancient example with a modern impression showing the carved design, see the Metropolitan Museum of Art, 1999.325.21, an Old Babylonian hematite seal. The projection Nina reports here belongs to the event, not to a documented property of the stone.

over, in a gallery where the humidity was held at a consistent forty-five percent.

A headache gathered behind Nina's eyes as the chant pressed on.

A seventh figure stood just outside the circle, watching rather than chanting. He was tall, perhaps fifty, in a long tailored coat, and his face had the calm of a conductor guiding an orchestra through a familiar score.

Without knowing how, Nina had crossed half the distance from the doorway to the group when he turned. His gaze moved from the badge at her hip to her face.

"Ms. Linder," he said, with a smile and the distracted nod of a professor adding a late student to his attendance list.

The chanting jumped out of time and scattered. Six faces turned toward her, bright with alarm and irritation.

Nina crossed the remaining floor toward the pedestal. The nearest woman moved aside, leaving a gap between the chanters. At her feet a curved line ran through the tile joints, scored so faintly that from the door Nina had taken it for a seam. Her next step crossed it. Cold passed through her coat as if someone had opened a door to winter.

The light was within reach now. The seal beneath it kept appearing and disappearing behind the script. She needed to see whether something was suspended over it—a film, a wire, a surface she could identify. Her phone was still in her right hand. Slowly she raised her left until her fingertips met the edge of the light.

The chanting faltered, scattered and uneven, and then stopped.

For a brief second the Museum's ordinary sounds came back, the hiss of the air handlers, a distant elevator relay, the building performing calm while it kept its measurements.

Heat pulsed through her palms. It did not hurt; it felt like weight finding its shape. Her skin tightened, and her wrists felt suddenly too narrow for what was moving through them.

The light did not pour out of the sphere into her. It rose out of her to meet it.

The leader stood motionless, his eyes moving from the sphere to her hands. His mouth opened a little; for the first time he seemed to have nothing ready to say.

Across the circle a man's voice said, "What are you—"

Nina's hands were already alight, and there was nothing ornamental about it: gold rose under the skin and threaded between her fingers, trac-

ing the vascular pathways with the sharp clarity of an energized circuit, and the glow caught in the chanters' eyes.

Then her phone rang, its hard, ordinary ringtone violent in that room.

Nina flinched. She had stepped into a pattern that forgave nothing, not even that. The light in her hands flickered. The sphere shuddered, and the luminous cuneiform lines on its surface smeared.

Her right hand recoiled, and the phone slipped away from her palm. It arced toward the gap between two chanters. The leader caught it just inside the scored circle, before it struck the stone.

The leader held the phone for a heartbeat, its screen lit against his fingers. Nina saw him glance down and nod once more, as if acknowledging another late student.

"I've got it," he said, entirely calm. "Don't worry. Your phone call can wait."

He came to the gap she had entered but kept his shoes outside the scored line. He offered his free hand without crossing it.

"Focus your energy," he said, more softly. "Stay with it."

Nina turned back to the cylinder. Around her the others closed ranks, leaving her beside the pedestal and the leader outside. She tried to hold her hands still. The phone had rung. A man had caught it. Those things she understood; the light rising through her skin she did not. She looked for the wire again, for anything that would make this an object rather than an impossibility. The sphere spun in bursts. Its script thickened and scattered, and the air seemed to stop.

"No," the leader snapped, and the calm sheared away. "She's not channeling—she's generating. Everyone, stabilize—now!"

But it was too late. Nina's light surged against the sphere. The luminous cuneiform wedges smeared and tore apart across the curved face, and the whole construct let go as old gilding can detach, all at once along a line hidden until the surface lifts.[5] The sphere collapsed in on itself, and the shockwave hit Nina in the chest and threw her backward.

As she flew, the word for what she was looking at slipped out of her mind. She usually had a catalog term for what she saw. Now she reached for one and found only an empty slot. The blank lasted perhaps two seconds; she felt shut out of her own language.

5. N. Linder, gallery event reconstruction, undated. In a gilded surface the metal leaf can remain intact while the ground or adhesive beneath it loses its hold; the visible lifting may begin at an edge too fine to see until it spreads. Nina records a resemblance in motion, not a recovered fragment from the light.

She slammed back against a display case hard enough to rattle its fittings, then fell to the floor, catching herself badly on her right hand. The air went out of her lungs, and the world narrowed to the taste of metal and a bright dark behind her eyes.

When her vision came back the golden sphere was gone. The candles were gone. On the exposed pedestal the seal was small and dark again; she could see the last condensation fading from its surface. The chanters had moved apart, glancing at each other like people caught in some mischief, as if they had never rehearsed this part. None came to help her.

The leader stood over her with her phone in his hand. For half a second his eyes were not on her at all but on the pedestal and the seal, and the look was one Nina knew from donor previews, a hunger wearing patience. He blinked, and when he faced her again he wore the mask of a teacher in wonder.

He knelt to examine her. His gaze followed her hands the same way Nina followed craquelure across old paint, attentive and clinical, looking for the pattern underneath.

"Remarkable," he murmured. "Completely untrained, and you collapsed a six-person ceremony."

Nina pushed herself upright. She was shaking, and heat still throbbed from her palms into her wrists.

"What did you do to me?" Her voice came out thin.

"I did nothing." His smile was precise. "You did that yourself."

He held out the phone. When she did not take it, he set it beside her and squared its edge with a seam in the floor. He made one small adjustment, then looked up, almost pleased. Even here, with the case open and Nina on the floor, he had found something he wanted orderly.

"How long have you been in love with someone impossible, now?"

Nina tried to steady her breath. Her chest hurt where the force had struck it.

"How do you know?"

The man's smile barely moved. "Because that's how it works."

He let the sentence stand. Then he took a card from his coat, white stock, cotton-heavy, too thick to be cheap, and held it out like an invitation and a price tag at once. His name was pressed into it without ink.

KONRAD WOLFORD

An address beneath it was embossed so shallowly that it read more like a bruise than like text.

"When you're ready," he said, "call me."

Nina would not take it. He had opened a case, used the seal and left her on the floor; now he was offering an introduction. She slapped it away, and the card skated across the stone floor and came to rest under a display case, bright as an insult.

The man—Konrad Wolford—did not react the way people react to being refused. He watched it go with the steady indifference of an instrument registering flow.

"You can throw paper," he said softly. "That doesn't mean you've refused the contact."

"Stay away from me."

His smile held. "You already touched it."

She didn't wait for whatever he meant by that. She snatched the phone off the floor, scrambled to her feet, and bolted toward the corridor. She hated that she was running—she could not watch the open case or account for what they might do behind her—but the instinct in her legs outran her discipline. She was in the service passage before her mind caught up with her fear. The back halls were colder and louder than the galleries, lit for work and not for show. At the turn in the passage she heard his voice behind her.

"You'll be back, Ms. Linder."

She did not turn to see how close he was. At the freight elevator she pressed the call button and looked at her phone while the car came up.

Missed call — 8:56 PM
OWEN RANDOLF

No voicemail. No message. Just proof that he had tried to reach her at the exact moment her hands were full of light.

She closed her eyes and gripped the phone until her knuckles ached. When she pushed it into her coat pocket, its edge struck something stiff already there.

She froze, then drew out a card, white and thick and cotton-heavy, and held it under the passage light.

KONRAD WOLFORD.

The same embossed address.

She hadn't picked it up. She had watched it slide away across the stone and watched it land, and yet here it was in her pocket, close to her body, resting against her ribs. Her refusal had been overwritten.

She crumpled it in her fist. The card fought her, as good rag paper always does. She pushed it back into her pocket.

The elevator arrived. She stepped inside and watched the doors meet before releasing her breath. At basement level she crossed to the heavy steel staff exit and pushed out into the cold October night.

Beneath a streetlight she felt something wrong in the rhythm at her feet. She stopped. Her shadow took another step, leaving a strip of bare pavement between it and her shoes, then snapped back. She stood until the chill at her neck had passed before she trusted herself to move.

At the corner she reached into her pocket for the phone and found the card lying beside it, flat. She drew it out. It was crisp and uncreased, and the only sign of her grip was a faint indentation where she had squeezed it, fading as she watched.

Nina slid the card into the archival sleeve she kept in her work bag, habit made portable.

"Neutral substrate," she whispered into the autumn cold. "Containment only. No engagement."

She walked at a pace she could hold all the way to the station. That much she could still choose.

Behind her the Museum went on glowing in its place, innocent as a lit case. Ahead of her the city held its grid. She would have to take the train home, unlock her own door, sleep somehow. The card was in her bag already.

Chapter One

Subject O. Randolf — Baseline Assessment

November 1, 2025

Owen Randolf lived on the third floor of a brownstone in Crown Heights, in an apartment that had begun as temporary housing. It had become permanent because he had stopped leaving.

On Saturday, November 1, 2025, the green digits on the microwave he never used said 12:40, and the loose transformer behind them hummed against the peeling laminate.

The apartment was two small rooms, a kitchen corner with a hot plate that had stopped working in March, a bathroom with its window painted shut, and, everywhere, books. The building had gone up in the 1890s as one family's house, and his share kept some of what it had been: ceilings higher than the rooms needed, a marble fireplace sealed with painted plywood, tall sash windows that rattled when the wind came from the west. The walls had been white when he moved in. There was little wall left to see.

The stacks rose in careful columns to the ceiling, in aisles so narrow that only Owen could walk them without bringing something down: worn paperbacks, ex-library hardcovers still wearing their white call numbers, a fantasy series in uniform editions making a parapet of identical spines, and one book that was not a story at all, its spine taped twice, Henry Petroski's *To Engineer Is Human*, which he had once assigned to a room of evening students as the only honest book about his profession, because it was about failure.[6]

Every column was doing a job, and together they made a fortress. Depression, for Owen, was a slow load failure; every morning, getting up from the mattress meant recalculating a compromised beam. Engineer-

6. Henry Petroski, *To Engineer Is Human: The Role of Failure in Successful Design* (New York: St. Martin's Press, 1985). Cited from O. Randolf's copy.

ing had not taught him to see it that way. It had only given him the words for what he already felt, and a feeling with a name could at least be measured. The books were counter-ballast. A stack he had steadied would still be there when he needed to stand.

Mornings began at noon. He woke, lay still and ran the diagnostic, finger, wrist, shoulder, looking for damage rather than hope. Beside the water glass on the nightstand stood an amber pharmacy bottle with his name on the label and, beneath it, the name of the psychiatrist who wrote the prescription: Dr. R. Shah. He took one tablet with the first mouthful of water, as he did every morning, and did not read the label. He knew what it said.[7]

The college had sent three emails about the spring term, and he had answered none of them. He had taught its evening course in ancient infrastructure for four years, aqueducts and roads and the underground structures beneath Hadrian's buildings, and then in March he had not gone back.

Then came maintenance. He did not read first; he stabilized the room. He knelt and ran his fingertips along the spines, correcting a tilt by a fraction of an inch, and moved one paperback from a tall tower to a short one. Less weight on the precarious stack, more on the one that could bear it. He used to ask his students where a Roman vault passed its load to the piers; here he could begin with a book he could lift.[8] When he got it right the apartment seemed quieter, though nothing in it had made a sound.

Only after that did he allow himself the small indulgence of plot. He sat cross-legged on the mattress with a paperback braced against his knees, its cover embossed in silver:

7. The file records that O. Randolf took one prescribed tablet each morning throughout these months. What it was prescribed for was his to say, and he did not say it; the file does not guess.

8. A vault does not carry its roof straight down; it turns the weight outward, into piers, walls and the mass behind them. Hadrian's Pantheon, for example, lightens its concrete from heavy aggregate at the base to lighter stone toward the crown, so the dome hands less load to the drum beneath. See William L. MacDonald, *The Pantheon: Design, Meaning, and Progeny* (Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press, 1976), and Lynne C. Lancaster, *Concrete Vaulted Construction in Imperial Rome: Innovations in Context* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2005). O. Randolf taught load paths to his evening students. His book stacks are independent columns, not a vault: redistributing their weight is an analogy for attending to support, not the same structural action.

THE WINDBORN ARCHIVES, VOLUME FOUR.

He thought he had bought the first volume after the first time something moved on his shelves; he could no longer put those two memories in an order he trusted. In the series the Windborn were watchers at gates and crossings, appearing in travelers' stories when a crossing needed watching, and only people under enough pressure could see them.[9] The author phrased it as myth. Owen read it as a warning label.

The radiator knocked, sharp and metallic, then rose into a note that sounded almost human if you wanted it to. Owen did not want it to.

At the edge of his vision something moved against the shelves. He did not look at once; looking made things commit to being there. One small shape perched on a stack of atlases, talons hooked over a dusty cover. Then two more. By the time he let himself look, there were six of them, no larger than housecats, narrow bodies armored in silver scales. Their amber eyes followed his hand when it shifted beside the book; when they blinked, a membrane closed across each eye like a shutter.

Owen did not say their name out loud. Saying it could make the worst things real in the wrong way.

The first sighting had been about five years ago. Since then they had come in periods, often in the gray hours after waking, when he could not easily tell exhaustion from something in the room. They left nothing he could show a doctor, and he had never described them to Dr. Shah. He imagined trying, and hearing the rest of his account dismissed with them.

Today they formed a perimeter along the shelves and windowsills. Owen kept his hands beside the book. Systems you could not control were safer when you did not provoke them into demonstrating that fact.

The page ended in a footnote, which quoted an anonymous *Notes on Threshold Observances*, a treatise on crossings and who was allowed to pass.[10] It was the kind of language Anton had used when he wanted to make Owen laugh: doors as politics, locks as philosophy, institutions as machines built to pretend they were neutral.

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9. *The Windborn Archives*, vol. IV, O. Randolf's reading copy. The watchers appear in stories and travelers' prohibitions. Randolf later said he believed the sightings preceded his reading; his own dated notes do not establish which came first. The series supplied the name he used.

10. Anonymous, *Notes on Threshold Observances*, fragment quoted in *The Windborn Archives*, vol. IV. No separate copy is identified in Randolf's papers; the citation records what he read, not an authenticated older manuscript.

Anton. The name sat in Owen's throat like a staple.

Anton had been the Museum's roaming consultant on ancient civilizations, the kind of man who turned up in the staff runs without belonging to any one department, credentialed by access and confidence. He had brought Owen in for exhibition installs and structural checks before anyone else at the Museum trusted him with them, and he had been the bridge between Owen and Nina Linder, a contractor who listened for failure and a conservator who spoke in measurements. Then Owen stopped coming. The contracts ended, the messages went unanswered, and the Museum forgot him.

Anton did not forget.

Anton had died in July, of a tumor in the left side of his brain that he had told almost no one about. The memorial had been the last time Owen and Nina stood face to face, trading a few sentences outside the reception-room doors, with no plan and no follow-up.

By early afternoon he had reached the bottom of the page three times. A hard rap sounded on the hallway door, two flat knocks on painted fir. At first Owen didn't move; in Crown Heights unexpected knocks usually meant someone bleeding the radiators. Then he unlocked the deadbolt.

Henderson, the building superintendent, stood on the runner with a clipboard and two banker boxes on a hand truck, his ring of master keys chiming against his work pants.

"de Soza's estate. New Haven," he said. "They've been downstairs since this morning. Sign here."

Owen took the pen. "Was there a letter?"

"Just the receipt. And keep the landing clear, will you? No old cartons out here."

Owen signed and kept the yellow copy. The new boxes would not fit beside the old ones by the closet, where Anton had left the first cartons in late June, a few weeks before the call that announced his death. Owen had moved those twice since, always lifting from the bottom, and had never opened them. Anton had brought them for the summer; until now Owen could leave them as Anton had left them. The last shipment made that impossible.

The oldest box said notebooks. If he could put notebooks on a shelf, he could nest one empty carton and win back his passage to the bathroom. He fetched the kitchen knife and cut the tape, keeping the blade shallow.

The smell reached him first: old paper, stale coffee, cigarette ash, Anton's life pressed into fiber and glue. Anton had once made him read the

German critic Walter Benjamin's talk about unpacking his library and had laughed at the line about the collector's passion bordering on the chaos of memories, because it described Owen exactly.[11] It did not seem funny now.

Inside were notebooks, dozens of them, bound and loose-leaf; printouts underlined so fiercely the paper had torn; photographs; envelopes. Beneath the last bundle lay a photograph taped to cardboard: a Mediterranean dig site, the sun too sharp to be northern, gravel terraces, men in hats, dust standing in the air. At the edge of the frame stood a man in an expensive coat, slightly out of focus and out of place among the rolled sleeves. Something about the face delayed Owen's hand. He held it closer to the window. The eyes would not resolve.

Three weeks ago, on a rare trip into Manhattan, he had stopped to watch a street magician in Washington Square, who had held a flame under his closed fist and opened it on a coin, then let a spectator inspect it. The coat in the photograph made him think of the show. He tried to picture the man who had stood beside the performer, and could not get a face to hold still.

Beside the photograph Anton had written, in blunt block letters:

KONRAD WOLFORD.[12]
not the donor — the handler.

A paper sleeve held more images: a black-and-white shot labeled 1979, a faded color print labeled 1988, a magazine clipping from 1997, a printout from 2015, a screenshot dated 2024. Different sites and cameras, and a similar face at the edge of each. Anyone could resemble anyone, and the captions were only Anton's handwriting. Owen had lived inside his own world for so long that he no longer fully trusted his sense of what was real and what he had only built, castles of books and perhaps now castles of the mind. Yet it had mattered enough to Anton to reach Crown Heights after his death.

11. Walter Benjamin, "Unpacking My Library: A Talk about Book Collecting" (1931), in *Illuminations*, ed. Hannah Arendt, trans. Harry Zohn (New York: Harcourt, Brace & World, 1968): "Every passion borders on the chaotic, but the collector's passion borders on the chaos of memories." A. de Soza's assignment, as O. Randolf reports it.

12. A. de Soza, caption to the mounted excavation photograph in the estate papers. The name is transcribed from the caption; at this point the identification had not been independently established.

He turned the pages of the top notebook. The margins were crowded with arrows, numbers and names crossed out and written again, and the same four words came back like bench marks on a survey:

Corridor. Witness. Recurrence. Solstice.

Beneath them was a list of years, each one circled:

1967, 1979, 1988, 1997, 2003, 2009, 2015, 2019, 2024.

On the inside cover of another, in block letters:

HE DOESN'T AGE.

The words left no room for the qualifications Owen would have liked to give them.

A loose sheet slid out from between the notebooks and landed face up.

THEY'RE MAKING MORE.

A second sentence sat beneath it, underlined three times:

HE IS BUILDING A DISTRIBUTION NETWORK.

More of what? Nothing on the back supplied the missing noun. Below it came the supporting notes, fear written as math: names, dates, cities; collectors and minor foundations; acquisitions followed by obituaries. At the bottom the line came back, pressed so hard into the paper that the strokes looked carved:

not the donor — the handler.

In the second box he found an unsealed envelope with a single index card inside, Anton's handwriting on one side and a phone number on the other. The words did not explain. They pointed.

St. Cyprian's. Bronx.
Fieldstone. Brass plate. CYPRIAN.
Basement.
Door always locked until it isn't.

Owen read it until he could recite it with his eyes closed. On the shelves the six watchers held their places; none had moved toward the papers.

He turned one last page before closing the notebook. There, beneath an acquisition code, was the name his mind drifted to and he never let himself say: Nina Linder.

He had met Nina through Anton, years ago, in the service corridor behind the Egyptian galleries during a donor preview, when a display bracket began to hum.

"It's too close to the wall," Nina had said, looking past Anton at the case.

"It has clearance," Owen said.

"It has clearance on paper."

Anton put a hand to his chest in mock injury. "At last. Two people who know the difference."

Owen crouched and found the vibration in the steel exactly where she had said it would be. "Another eighth of an inch," he told the installer.

"Three sixteenths," Nina said. "The stone moves with temperature."

"Three sixteenths."

The installer loosened the bolts. The hum dropped but did not disappear.

Owen pressed two fingers to the frame. "The glass is carrying it now. I can isolate anything. The trouble is the vibration never just goes away. Something else picks up the load, and you have to know what."

She pointed to the plaster seam behind the case. "We keep photographs of that crack. It opens and closes a little over the year. If the frame bears on the wall, I want to know what happens at the other end."

He looked up. She was watching the gap, not waiting to be told the vibration had stopped. He asked for a neoprene washer and rebuilt the contact point while she watched, and the vibration thinned to silence.

"Now it has clearance," Owen said. "On paper and off."

Anton smiled. Owen understood later that Anton had arranged the exchange. After that, Owen and Nina kept ending up in the same building: coffee when schedules overlapped, short lunches in staff spaces that smelled of detergent and old stone. Neither asked the other to account for the time.

He had liked the way she said three sixteenths: certain of what she had seen, willing to make him check it. It had been easy to call his attention professional. Then his depression had made even structure difficult, and he had stopped answering. He could not imagine bringing her into the apartment as it was.

April 3 stood beside Nina's name; the date told him nothing. Below it Anton had written a Museum acquisition code and St. Medard's, and a folder in the box bore the same label: names, placement dates, pairs on separate sheets. Anton had known them both through the Museum.

That did not explain putting her in these pages. His fingers shook against the paper. She would know how to check an acquisition code; he had watched her refuse a clean-looking surface until she had seen the repair underneath. First he would have to ask whether she wanted to see it.

As dusk settled, Owen picked up his phone to write to her. The Phone app opened where he had left it. In Recents was an entry he had expected not to be there.

> Friday, 8:56 PM. Nina Linder. Outgoing. No answer.

On Friday he had been sitting beside the taped boxes with a lexicon on his knee when the screen changed to her name. He remembered the outgoing tone, but not finding her contact or pressing Call. Here was the call. He must have made it. It was the same uncertain border where the Windborn lived, between what he saw and what he did.[13]

He opened her thread in Messages, typed one line and deleted it. He didn't want to be the man who delivered panic, and he didn't want to be wrong. There was nothing new from her.

Outside, the November dusk pushed cold drafts through the rattling sash windows. Inside, the fortress held, and the six watchers did not move. Tomorrow he could begin with one question: where had Anton expected someone to go? He picked up the card and read it once more.

13. Daryl J. Bem, "Self-Perception: An Alternative Interpretation of Cognitive Dissonance Phenomena," *Psychological Review* 74 (1967): 183–200, considers how people infer attitudes from their conduct and its circumstances. The call entry here records an action; Randolf supplies its intention.

End of the sneak preview

The Corridors of Hadrian continues in Chapter Two.

The complete manuscript is available to agents and publishers on request:
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